

Mav and the Bitter-Lemonade Hustle

Maverick stood behind a wooden crate in the Clovis town square. On the front, a sign written in crayon and professional drafting ink read: "**BUCKTOOTH & MAV'S STRUCTURALLY SUPERIOR LEMONADE - \$1.00 (NO REFUNDS FOR STRUCTURAL FAILURE).**"

"Maverick! We have only made four dollars!" the Bucktooth doll squeaked, his button eyes scanning the park. "At this rate, we will not reclaim our ten billion dollars until the year 3402! We need to optimize our citrus-to-sugar ratio and increase our predatory marketing!"

"We're doing fine, Professor," Mav said, stirring a pitcher with a wooden spoon. "People like the homemade touch."

For thirty minutes, business was booming. But then, the line evaporated. Maverick looked across the path and saw their doom: a neon-yellow booth covered in flashing lights and spinning propeller hats. A sign above it read: "**SPINNY HAT SPRITZERS - NOW WITH 40% MORE LOGO!**"

"A competitor?!" Bucktooth shrieked, his felt fur standing on end. "This is an act of economic warfare! Look at those signs! They lack proper kerning! And those hats? They provide zero aerodynamic benefit! It is a foundational mockery of the refreshment industry!"

Bucktooth immediately grabbed a picket sign that said "**UNFAIR TO BEAVERS**" and began scuttling in circles in front of the rival stand, chanting about the "tyranny of the propeller hat." When that failed to stop the crowd, the Professor turned to Mav with a manic glint in his eye.

"Maverick! Distract them! I am deploying the **Bitrex 5000!**"

While Mav pretended to do a cartwheel, the Professor scuttled over and emptied a vial of the world's most bitter chemical into the rival's pitcher. Seconds later, every kid wearing a spinny hat let out a strangled yelp and made a face like they were trying to swallow a lemon-scented battery.

"Victory!" Bucktooth cheered. "The market has corrected itself!"

But then, a tiny, slow-moving turtle named **Buckley** waddled up to the ruined stand. He looked at the empty jar of coins and let out a tiny, heartbreaking sob.

"Oh, no," Buckley whimpered, a single turtle-tear rolling down his beak. "We didn't make enough. Now I'll never get my special glasses. I just want to be able to read my science books without my eyes feeling like they're full of sand. I guess I'll just be a humble, illiterate turtle forever."

Maverick and the Professor felt a sudden, sharp pang of guilt.

"Professor," Mav whispered. "He's a turtle who wants to read. We can't be responsible for a science-less turtle."

"You're right, Maverick," the doll sighed, his button eyes softening. "Education is the foundation of a solid dam. Here, little one!"

Mav reached into their earnings and handed Buckley the remaining difference for his glasses. "Go on, Buckley. Get those specs. For science."

"Oh, thank you!" Buckley cheered, grabbing the cash. "I'm going to rush home and tell my parents! You've changed my life!"

Buckley turned and began to speed-waddle away. About fifty feet out, he stopped and squinted at a small sign by the park exit. "Let's see... the sign says 'Park Closes at 8:00 PM'... oh no, I'm late for my favorite show!"

Maverick froze. "Wait. Did he just read that sign? From fifty feet away?"

"The little scoundrel!" Bucktooth roared. "His vision is structurally perfect! He played us for fools! He's a tactical hustler in a green shell!"

"Hey! Get back here!" Mav yelled.

Just then, **Cheap Whiskey** wandered into the park, looking dazed. A stray soccer ball rolled toward his feet. "Yo, monkes! Watch this legendary goal!"

Cheap Whiskey wound up for a massive kick, but his eyes were unfocused. He missed the ball entirely and his sneaker connected squarely with the back of Buckley's shell.

THWACK.

The turtle was launched like a leafy-green frisbee, soaring across the park and vanishing over the horizon with a faint "I regret nothing!" echoed in the wind.

"Whoops," Cheap Whiskey muttered, stumbling. "Sorry, Mav. I had too much of Taffy's 'Hyper-Lemonade' earlier. My depth perception is currently vibrating at a frequency I don't recognize. Why is that turtle in the air?"

"He was a hustler, Whiskey!" Bucktooth explained, dusting off his felt paws. "You just delivered a swift, uncoordinated strike of Beaver Justice!"

"I'll take it," Cheap Whiskey shrugged, falling over into a bed of petunias.

They all had a big laugh, deciding that while they were still \$9,999,999,996 short of their goal, their work for the day was done. They spent the evening playing a glitchy version of tag while Taffy Stamburger watched from the sidelines, wearing a pimp coat and eating a taco.

Meanwhile, in a dark sewer at the edge of town, a very dizzy turtle named Buckley looked around. "Hello?" he squeaked. "It's very damp here. And I think I lost my science money. Is there anyone here with a structural understanding of exits?!"